



AI-DRIVEN COST MODEL

Building Without Human Effort

What it costs to build and run SwapHub when an AI coding agent does the engineering — replacing developer salaries with a software subscription.

SwapHub project · **July 2026**

Scope: early app, ~1,000 users, trade-only · FX: 1 USD ≈ **₱57**

Proof point: this app's prototype, deployment, and GitHub setup were all done this way.

The idea in one line

The largest cost of software is not servers — it is developer labour. When an AI agent (Cursor) writes and maintains the code under your direction, that labour cost collapses into a monthly subscription, and the remaining spend is mostly infrastructure.

₱10k–35k

To build the app (AI subscription)

₱140k–155k

All-in, 2 years

₱210k–270k

All-in, 3 years

~75–80%

Cheaper than hiring

Headline

Building and running SwapHub "without human effort" costs roughly **₱210k–270k over 3 years** (≈ ₱6k/month) — versus ~₱1.1M–2.0M to hire a developer, or ₱2.5M+ via an agency. The AI does the coding; the biggest remaining cost is infrastructure.

Cursor plans (July 2026)

Plan	USD / mo	≈ PHP / mo	Best for
Pro	\$20	₱1,140	Daily use, maintenance
Pro+	\$60	₱3,420	Heavy building sprints
Ultra	\$200	₱11,400	Full-time agentic building

All paid plans include unlimited "Auto" model and Tab completions. ~20% cheaper billed annually. Pro is sufficient for a small app; a couple of Pro+ months help during the initial build.

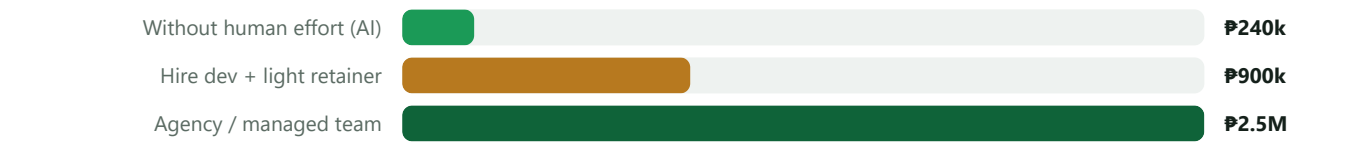
The cost model

Cash cost = AI subscription + infrastructure + store/domain fees. Developer salaries and agency fees disappear; your own time replaces them.

Line-by-line vs hiring a developer

Cost line	Without human effort (AI)	Hire a developer
Initial build	₱10k–35k (AI sub while building)	₱400k–800k
Dev labour / maintenance (3 yr)	₱0 cash (your time)	₱540k–1.08M
AI subscription (3 yr)	₱45k–70k	optional
Infrastructure (3 yr)	₱144k	₱144k
Store + domain (3 yr)	₱18k	₱18k
3-year total	₱210k–270k	₱1.1M–2.0M

3-year all-in cost by approach



Midpoint 3-year totals · bars scaled to the agency figure.

Monthly run cost (steady state, ~1k users)

Item	Tier	₱ / month
Cursor (maintenance mode)	Pro	₱1,140
Supabase (DB, auth, storage, realtime)	Pro	₱1,425
Web hosting (Vercel)	Pro	₱1,140
Images, email, monitoring, push	Free tiers	₱0
Domain	Annual	₱85
Typical monthly		~₱3,800–6,000

What "without human effort" really means

The AI removes the *engineering* effort and cost — not every human touch. It is a force multiplier on one person, not a fully autonomous company. Here is the honest split.

The AI handles

- Writing all application code (frontend, backend, database)
- Wiring auth, listings, photos, search, chat, offers
- Setting up and deploying infrastructure
- Fixing bugs and applying updates on request
- Version control, GitHub, and deployment pipelines
- Documentation and technical decisions

You still provide

- Product direction and decisions
- Testing sign-off — confirming things work as intended
- Cloud & store accounts (Supabase, Vercel, Apple, Google)
- App-store submission and review responses
- User support and responding to incidents
- Business, legal, and privacy compliance

Your time is the real input

Expect roughly **4–10 weeks of focused part-time effort** to build the lean app by directing the AI, then a **few hours per month** to maintain it. That time is the cost that replaces a developer salary — no cash, but real involvement.

Why this works here

This isn't hypothetical for SwapHub: the working prototype, its public deployment on Vercel, and the GitHub repository were all produced through this exact AI-driven workflow — at nothing more than subscription cost.

Bottom line: Maximizing the AI puts the realistic 3-year cost at **₱210k–270k** (≈ ₱6k/month), dominated by infrastructure rather than labour. It trades cash for your direct involvement — the cheapest viable path to build and run SwapHub.

All figures are planning ranges for the Philippine market as of July 2026, not fixed quotes. Cursor pricing per cursor.com (July 2026). FX 1 USD ≈ ₱57. Live prototype: swaphub-web.vercel.app